BATTLE OF THE NARRATIVES

How the Centre, the Congress/INDIA bloc and the CJP are navigating the agitation against the ECI

The Modi regime seeks to contain the protests without appearing repressive

- Stand by the EC, defend the SIR to avoid undermining its electoral legitimacy
- Disrupt protests before they gather momentum, without the images of police brutality
- Recast voter deletions as a crackdown on 'infiltrators'
- Portray CJP as a security and 'anti-national' threat, dismiss Congress as a sore loser
- Encourage Congress-CJP rivalry for young voters, to fragment anti-BJP sentiment

Congress/INDIA bloc wants to turn the ECI, SIR issues into a sustained offensive

- Turn allegations of electoral manipulation into a wider challenge to Modi govt's mandate
- Mobilise district/state networks for prolonged protests, with Delhi as the epicentre
- Combine public agitation with parliamentary confrontation, judicial scrutiny of ECI
- Keep campaign focus on deleted rolls, electoral integrity
- Support CJP without conceding leadership or allowing it to dominate agitation

The CJP is looking to channel state repression into political momentum

- Decentralise protests. Replace blocked Delhi mobilisation with state logjams, jail *bharo* campaigns
- Turn repression into resistance. Use arrests to rally support around democratic rights and patriotism
- Convert student activism, grassroots mobilisation and online outrage into sustained political pressure
- Preserve independence. Welcome Oppn support, remain outside the INDIA bloc

about the electoral process. "We can't leave the field open for Modi to choose the opposition of his choice," says Pawan Khera, Rajya Sabha MP and head of the AICC's media and publicity department.

The legal offensive is a bit more nuanced. Rather than directly challenging the SC's May 27 judgment upholding the ECI's authority to conduct the SIR, the INDIA bloc petition raises a more focused point. Was the exercise carried out lawfully, through decisions taken collectively by the commission? It seeks access to the ECI files and database-access logs, booth-wise disclosure of voter deletions, an independent audit and an interim suspension of the SIR. The attempt is to shift judicial scrutiny to the way the commission's powers are exercised.

THE ROACHES DIG IN

October 10 was meant to showcase the CJP's ability to mobilise independently of established political parties. Instead, police detained its leaders, Abhijeet Dipke, Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka, as soon as their flight landed in Delhi. Jantar Mantar was sealed within a four-kilometre exclusion zone, entry was restricted at 45 metro stations and mobile internet was suspended in central Delhi. Barricades prevented protesters from assembling. Delhi Police reported nearly 2,500 detentions, the SC petitioners put the number at 7,000.

ON CEC KUMAR, THE CENTRE HAS LITTLE ROOM FOR MANOEUVRE. ANY ACTION WOULD BE INFERRED AS AN ADMISSION OF GUILT

The crackdown forced a tactical shift. On October 12, the CJP leadership met some 150 state coordinators and decided to decentralise the agitation. Dipke announced a Jail Bharo Andolan in Mumbai, while Maharashtra organiser Ajinkya Shinde proposed protests in Goa, Bengaluru, Kolkata and Ranchi. "Wherever they stop you will become your Jantar Mantar," he told supporters.

On October 13, Delhi Police withdrew Jantar Mantar's status as a designated protest site. The CJP immediately turned "Give us back Jantar Mantar" into its new rallying cry. The next day, Das and Ranka, who had crossed the barricades carrying the tricolour, were remanded to five days in judicial custody. By portraying their arrests as punishment for carrying the national flag, the CJP turned the dispute over a protest venue into a question of patriotism and democratic rights.

Denied a central stage, the CJP is now dispersing its protests and turning police action into political publicity. The strategy may guarantee visibility and online outrage, but whether the CJP can translate this into sustained pressure on the government remains uncertain.

The Congress-CJP relationship has evolved from competitive distance to cautious convergence. After the arrests of Das and Ranka, Rahul declared that waving the tricolour at Jantar Mantar was "not a crime" and jailing youth for it was "an act